

Castle for the position you have

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

Castling usually improves king safety and rook coordination, but its value depends on the pawn shelter and enemy attack. Decide which side is safer rather than treating a move number as a deadline. Delaying without a concrete reason can become costly.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If your kingside pawns have advanced far and the opponent has open files there, kingside castling may enter the attack. Queenside castling also needs an inspection of the c-file, diagonal access, and the king's future escape squares.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What should you inspect before choosing a castling side?

ANSWER AND REASONING

The pawn cover, open lines, nearby enemy pieces, and how quickly your opponent can open more lines. Compare that with the danger of leaving the king in the center.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Castle into safety, not merely out of habit.